



Daniel Chapo

(CHAH-poh)

President
Republic of Mozambique

Addressed as: **Your Excellency** | Office held since: **Jan 2025**

Daniel Chapo, who had a limited national profile before being tapped by ruling party FRELIMO as its presidential candidate, is betting on his deliberate, unflashy approach to leadership to steer his country through economic and security challenges.

▣ **A Generational Inheritance**

As the first Mozambican head of state born after independence, Chapo casts himself as both an heir to the liberation movement and the leader of the generation charged with consolidating what it won.

▣ **An Administrative Sensibility**

Chapo is focused on processes and bureaucratic efficiencies, drawing on his experiences as a provincial administrator. He has boasted that his administration had completed 92 of 96 steps in its first-100-day plan.

Chapo describes his career as a chain of missions rather than ambitions: "In FRELIMO we are given missions." He has pledged that he would not be a "distant President, but a son of the nation."

WHY THEY MATTER

Chapo treats oil and gas as the backbone of his development agenda, spending his first 18 months in office rewriting contracts and legislation and revitalizing security arrangements to protect investments.

▣ **Restarting Mega-Projects**

Chapo presided over the relaunch of the roughly \$20 billion Mozambique LNG project at Afungi and has publicly stated he expects ExxonMobil's final investment decision by September 2026.

▣ **Relitigating Mozambican Benefits**

This year, he signed LNG Local Content and Mining Laws, both of which strengthen requirements for local participation and domestic economic benefit in critical sectors. He has separately pressed for skills transfers from energy companies to young Mozambicans.

Chapo, who reshuffled his military commanders and secured continued EU and Rwandan support, is fixated on the nexus between security and energy abundance. In July, he stated that "the security and peace in Mozambique are, consequently, the energy security of the world."

MEETING WITH THEM

Chapo is a straightforward and generally unflappable interlocutor, steadily delivering his points and reframing contentious issues to stay on message.

▣ **From Abstract to Concrete**

When responding to inquiries, Chapo zooms out to provide context or falls back on axioms to guide the conversation—it also helps him to defuse difficult subjects. He then adds facts, figures, and details to strengthen his points.

▣ **From Portuguese to English**

In Portuguese, he is fluent, formal, and layered — long subordinate clauses, connectors like *portanto* ("therefore"), *daí que* ("hence"), *em função disso* ("accordingly"). In English, he strips down to short declarative sentences and uses humor to deflect: "you know that my official language is Portuguese but I will try to speak English. My English is very bad."

Chapo's cadence, with a special emphasis on repetition ("serve the people, serve the people, serve the people, right up to today"), may stem from his days as a radio announcer and later as a television presenter, hosting the public affairs program "A Voz do Povo" (The Voice of the People).

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **Xenophobic Threats in South Africa**

Mozambique said two of its citizens were killed and another two injured in anti-migrant unrest in South Africa in mid-July. Hundreds of Mozambicans have returned home during the last two months.

▣ **Russian Foreign Minister's Visit**

During a trip in mid-July, Russian foreign minister Sergey Lavrov offered Moscow's help and readiness to "respond to a request from our Mozambican friends regarding the support we can provide in eliminating the terrorist threat that persists in the north of the country."

▣ **Mozambique Pays \$700 Million IMF Debt Early**

Mozambique repaid about \$700 million to the International Monetary Fund ahead of schedule and in full. The IMF said a staff visit to the country is likely in the coming months, presumably to continue negotiations for an IMF-funded program.

▣ **Flood Recovery Efforts**

NGOs and other partners continue to assist in recovery efforts following devastating floods that displaced some 600,000 people across southern Mozambique in the first half of 2026.

NETWORK

Chapo has prioritized expanding his international network, engaging with major powers and cementing strategic partnerships with Rwandan President Paul Kagame and Tanzanian President Samia Suluhu Hassan.

Chapo is one of the few African leaders to meet Vice President JD Vance, was the first African head of state to make a state visit to China in 2026, and committed to attend the Third Russia-Africa Summit in October. His vital security partnership with Kagame appears grounded in a burgeoning friendship as well as military cooperation whereas his warm ties to Samia reflect the shared liberation heritage of FRELIMO and Tanzania's ruling party.

Chapo's domestic support is more institutional than personal, resting on backing from FRELIMO and endorsements from past presidents.

While Chapo won the party's nomination as a compromise candidate after the central committee rejected another contender, he managed to secure support from FRELIMO's leading lights, including former presidents Filipe Nyusi and Armando Guebuza, as well as Graça Machel, who said he was her candidate and his leadership corresponded with the principles valued by the Machel family.

CONTROVERSIES

Chapo's image as a humble but capable public servant has been shadowed by the manner of his arrival in office and transparency questions.

▣ A Contested Mandate

He was declared winner of the October 2024 election with roughly two-thirds of the vote, a result the opposition rejected as systematically rigged. The declaration triggered months of violent protest and dozens of deaths.

▣ A Conflict of Interest

The Centre for Public Integrity raised compliance questions about six companies Chapo held shares in and about business overlaps among his ministers, as well as objected to substantial gifts he accepted—though the public-ethics commission cleared him on the gifts.

Chapo has come under fire for the security services' heavy handed approach to civilian protests and counterterrorism operations in the oil-rich Cabo Delgado region. In February 2025, he said "just as we are fighting terrorism and there are young people who are shedding their blood for the territorial integrity of Mozambique, for the sovereignty of Mozambique, to maintain our independence here in Cabo Delgado, even if we have to shed blood to defend this homeland against demonstrations, we will shed blood."

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- ▣ **President**, Republic of Mozambique (2025 - present)
- ▣ **Interim Secretary-General**, FRELIMO (2024 to 2025)
- ▣ **Governor**, Inhambane Province (2016 to 2024)
- ▣ **Deputy Administrator**, Palma, Cabo Delgado (2015 to 2016)
- ▣ **Lecturer in Political Science and Constitutional Law**, Maputo Pedagogical University (2009)
- ▣ **Notary Public & Conservator**, Legal Registry, Nacala Porto (2005)
- ▣ **Radio & Television Presenter**, Rádio and Televisão Miramar (1997 to 2004)

BIO

Chapo's story is one of hardship, mobility, and steady institutional rise. Born on January 6, 1977, in the railway town of Inhaminga in Sofala Province, he is the sixth of ten children of a Mozambique Railways employee. He attended Eduardo Mondlane University, Mozambique's premier institution, graduating with a bachelor's degree in law in 2000.

- ▣ **Defined by the Civil War**

When he was five years old, Chapo and his family were captured by RENAMO guerrillas and spent about two years in captivity. They escaped on foot, returned to a devastated Inhaminga, and later relocated to Dondo. He detailed his experiences in his 2026 autobiography entitled *Do Cativo à Presidência da República* (From Captivity to the Presidency of the Republic).

- ▣ **Shaped by Sports**

Chapo—who towers over counterparts at 6 feet, 8 inches—played basketball as a young man, starting with Ferroviário do Dondo and later for Ferroviário da Beira. He also plays football, and is an avid supporter of the Mambas, Mozambique's national football team.

Chapo has been married to Gueta Selemene Chapo since 2009; she now heads FRELIMO's women's wing, and the couple keep their four children out of public view. He is Christian and multilingual, speaking Portuguese, English, and three central and southern Mozambican languages (Xisena, Xindau, and Xitswa).